

How old was Noah when Shem was born?

At first glance of [Genesis 5:32](#), this might seem like a simple question to answer. But, if you don't look carefully at the rest of scripture you can easily make a mistake.

[Genesis 5:32](#)

And Noah was **five hundred years old**: and Noah begat Shem, Ham, and Japheth.

- Let's assume for a moment that Noah was 500 when Shem was born.

[Genesis 7:6](#)

And Noah was **six hundred years old** when the flood of waters was upon the earth.

[Genesis 7:11](#)

¶ In the **six hundredth year of Noah's life**, in the second month, the seventeenth day of the month, the same day were all the fountains of the great deep broken up, and the windows of heaven were opened.

- The flood came in the 600th year of Noah's life.
- Based on our previous assumption that would make Shem 100 years old when the flood came
 - $500 + 100 = 600$

[Genesis 11:10](#)

¶ These are the generations of Shem: **Shem was an hundred years old**, and begat Arphaxad **two years after the flood**:

- Let's also assume from this verse that Shem was 100 years old when he begat Arphaxad and that was also 2 years after the flood.

But, wait. If the flood came when Shem was 100 years old that would make him 102 years old 2 years after the flood not 100 years old. So, we made a mistake somewhere. And that mistake was in our interpretation of either [Genesis 5:32](#) and [Genesis 11:10](#) because both of those assumptions cannot be true at the same time.

Assuming our mistake was in how we read Genesis 5:32:

Noah was 500 when he *began* to begat Shem, Ham, and Japheth. Noah was 502 when he begat Shem. That would make Shem 102 years old 2 years after the flood.

Assuming our mistake was in how we read Genesis 11:10:

Shem was 100 years old. When Shem was 102 years old he begat Arphaxad which was also 2 years after the flood.

Because of the comma in [Genesis 11:10](#) I lean more towards Shem was 100 years old when he begat Arphaxad and that also was 2 years after the flood. Which would mean that Noah was 502 years old when Shem was born.